Nursing Exam Preparation: NCLEX-RN / NCLEX-PN

Content Package for medihelp.live

> **Note on naming:** The correct exam names are **NCLEX-RN** (National Council Licensure Examination – Registered Nurse) and **NCLEX-PN** (Practical Nurse), administered by the National Council of State Boards of Nursing (NCSBN). This content package reflects the **2026 Test Plan**, effective April 1, 2026 – March 31, 2029, which uses the Next Generation NCLEX (NGN) format introduced in 2023 (the core structure and question types are unchanged in 2026 — only minor wording/category-name updates were made).

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1. Exam Pattern (Both Exams)

Feature	NCLEX-RN	NCLEX-PN
Format	Computerized Adaptive Testing (CAT)	Computerized Adaptive Testing (CAT)
Number of items	85–150 (variable length)	85–150 (variable length)
Time limit	5 hours (includes tutorial, breaks)	5 hours (includes tutorial, breaks)
Question types	Multiple choice, Select-All-That-Apply (SATA), drag-and-drop, cloze/drop-down, highlight, matrix/grid, bow-tie, trend items, extended multiple response	Same NGN item types as RN, calibrated to LPN/VN scope of practice
Clinical judgment items	18 case-study items (3 item sets) + ~10% stand-alone clinical judgment items	Same structure, scaled to PN scope
Scoring model	NCSBN Clinical Judgment Measurement Model (CJMM): Recognize cues → Analyze cues → Prioritize hypotheses → Generate solutions → Take action → Evaluate outcomes	Same CJMM model
Passing standard	Fixed logit standard set by NCSBN (pass/fail, not percentage-based)	Fixed logit standard set by NCSBN
Retake policy	Governed by individual State Board of Nursing (typically 45-day wait)	Same, per State Board

Key takeaway for your course page: Emphasize that both exams test *clinical judgment and decision-making*, not rote memorization — this should shape how sample questions and study material are framed.

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2. Course Structure by Subject / Subtopic

Both exams are organized around NCSBN's **4 Client Needs Categories** (2 of which split into subcategories). Use this exact structure for your course modules — it mirrors what students will see in the official test plan and in every major prep resource (Saunders, Kaplan, UWorld), so it will feel familiar to learners.

A. NCLEX-RN Course Structure

Module	Client Needs Category	Weight	Core Subtopics
1	**Safe & Effective Care Environment** — Management of Care	15–21%	Care coordination, delegation & supervision, ethical/legal practice, informed consent, advance directives, prioritization, referrals, quality improvement, unbiased/equitable care
2	**Safe & Effective Care Environment** — Safety & Infection Prevention and Control	10–16%	Standard/transmission precautions, hazardous materials, error prevention, use of restraints, home safety, emergency response planning
3	**Health Promotion & Maintenance**	6–12%	Growth & development (lifespan), antepartum/intrapartum/postpartum care, newborn care, health screening, immunizations, lifestyle choices, disease prevention
4	**Psychosocial Integrity**	6–12%	Coping mechanisms, mental health disorders, substance misuse, grief/loss, abuse/neglect, therapeutic communication, crisis intervention, cultural/spiritual support
5	**Physiological Integrity** — Basic Care & Comfort	6–12%	Mobility/immobility, nutrition, elimination, rest/sleep, non-pharmacological comfort measures, personal hygiene & dignity
6	**Physiological Integrity** — Pharmacological & Parenteral Therapies	12–18%	Medication administration, IV therapy, blood products, pain management, expected/adverse effects, high-alert medications
7	**Physiological Integrity** — Reduction of Risk Potential	9–15%	Diagnostic tests, lab values, potential complications, vital sign monitoring, invasive procedures, internal monitoring devices

Module	Client Needs Category	Weight	Core Subtopics
8	**Physiological Integrity** — Physiological Adaptation	11–17%	Fluid & electrolyte balance, medical emergencies, pathophysiology, hemodynamics, unstable clients

Cross-cutting integrated processes taught throughout all modules: Clinical Judgment (CJMM), Caring, Communication & Documentation, Teaching/Learning.

B. NCLEX-PN Course Structure

Module	Client Needs Category	Weight (approx.)	Core Subtopics
1	**Coordinated Care**	18–24%	Scope of practice for LPN/VN, delegation to unlicensed staff, care planning, legal responsibilities, referrals, continuity of care
2	**Safety & Infection Prevention and Control**	10–16%	Infection control, safe use of equipment, error prevention, environmental safety
3	**Health Promotion & Maintenance**	6–12%	Developmental stages, antepartum/postpartum/newborn care, health screening, self-care
4	**Psychosocial Integrity**	9–15%	Mental health concepts, coping, substance misuse, therapeutic communication, end-of-life care
5	**Physiological Integrity** — Basic Care & Comfort	7–13%	ADLs, nutrition, mobility, comfort interventions, personal hygiene
6	**Physiological Integrity** — Pharmacological Therapies	10–16%	Medication administration principles, pharmacokinetics, adverse reactions
7	**Physiological Integrity** — Reduction of Risk Potential	9–15%	Monitoring for complications, diagnostic test follow-up, vital signs
8	**Physiological Integrity** — Physiological Adaptation	7–13%	(Largest combined share: Physiological Integrity = 33–57% overall) Acute changes in body systems, medical emergencies

> Tip for the course page: present RN and PN side-by-side (as above) so students preparing for either exam — or bridging from PN to RN — can see the overlap and the differences at a glance.

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3. Sample Exam Questions

NCLEX-RN Sample Questions

1. Multiple Choice (Pharmacological Therapies) A client is prescribed warfarin. Which lab value should the nurse monitor to evaluate therapeutic effectiveness? A) Partial thromboplastin time (PTT) B) International Normalized Ratio (INR) C) Platelet count D) Hemoglobin A1c *(Answer: B)*

2. Select All That Apply — SATA (Physiological Adaptation) A nurse is caring for a client in early septic shock. Which findings should the nurse expect? (Select all that apply.) ☐ Fever ☐ Tachycardia ☐ Bradypnea ☐ Hypotension ☐ Warm, flushed skin *(Answer: Fever, Tachycardia, Hypotension, Warm/flushed skin)*

3. Next Generation — Bow-Tie Item (Clinical Judgment: Physiological Adaptation) A client presents with chest pain radiating to the left arm, diaphoresis, and nausea.

- *Left side (cause):* Select the most likely condition.
- *Middle (actions):* Select 2 priority nursing actions.
- *Right side (outcomes):* Select 2 expected outcomes of correct action. *(Format tests full clinical reasoning chain — condition: Acute MI; actions: obtain 12-lead ECG, administer aspirin/oxygen per protocol; outcomes: relief of pain, stable vitals.)*

4. Prioritization (Management of Care) The nurse is assigned four clients at the start of a shift. Which client should the nurse assess first? A) A client 2 days post-op with a pain rating of 4/10 B) A client with a new onset of slurred speech and facial drooping C) A client requesting a scheduled medication D) A client due for a routine dressing change *(Answer: B — signs of possible stroke)*

NCLEX-PN Sample Questions

1. Multiple Choice (Coordinated Care) Which task can the LPN safely delegate to unlicensed assistive personnel (UAP)? A) Administering an oral medication B) Taking a client's temperature C) Assessing a new wound D) Developing a discharge teaching plan *(Answer: B)*

2. SATA (Basic Care & Comfort) Which interventions are appropriate for a client with impaired mobility? (Select all that apply.) ☐ Repositioning every 2 hours ☐ Encouraging ambulation as tolerated ☐ Applying antiembolism stockings ☐ Restricting fluid intake ☐ Performing passive range-of-motion exercises *(Answer: Repositioning, ambulation, stockings, ROM exercises)*

3. Cloze/Drop-down (Pharmacological Therapies) A client receiving IV potassium chloride reports burning at the IV site. The LPN should first [dropdown: notify the RN / slow the infusion rate / apply a warm compress / continue and document]. *(Answer: notify the RN — infiltration/extravasation risk)*

4. Prioritization (Safety & Infection Control) Which client should the LPN report to the RN immediately? A) Client with a temperature of 37.8°C B) Client with new confusion and decreased urine output C) Client requesting pain medication D) Client ambulating in the hallway *(Answer: B — possible sepsis/AKI)*

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4. Top 3 Recommended Books — NCLEX-RN

These three are consistently ranked as the gold-standard, most widely followed resources by nursing programs and NCLEX candidates:

1. **Saunders Comprehensive Review for the NCLEX-RN Examination** (Silvestri & Silvestri) — <cite index="21-1,21-2">Currently in its later editions, it is consistently ranked among the most popular study aids on the market, offering over 1,000 pages of content review with strategies for the exam.</cite> Best for **complete content review** across all 8 categories, with the largest practice question bank of any single book.
2. **Kaplan NCLEX-RN Prep Plus** (Kaplan Test Prep) — <cite index="21-3">Built around Kaplan's Decision Tree method to strengthen reasoning and analytical skills for tackling exam questions.</cite> Best for **test-taking strategy and critical thinking**, ideal for students who know the content but need help with question logic.
3. **UWorld NCLEX-RN QBank** — <cite index="29-1">Widely regarded as one of the toughest and most respected question banks in the nursing community, valued for its detailed rationales explaining both correct and incorrect answers.</cite> Best for **practice-question mastery and simulation of NGN item difficulty**.

(Commonly paired combination recommended across review sites: Saunders or HESI for content → Kaplan for strategy → UWorld for practice-question mastery.)

5. Top 3 Recommended Books — NCLEX-PN

1. **Saunders Comprehensive Review for the NCLEX-PN Examination** (Silvestri) — the PN counterpart of the RN edition; same trusted content-review format, mapped to LPN/VN scope of practice and the Coordinated Care framework.
2. **Kaplan's NCLEX-PN Content Review Guide** — mirrors the RN version's strategy-first approach, adapted to PN-level delegation, safety, and basic care content.
3. **HESI Comprehensive Review for the NCLEX-PN Examination** — <cite index="27-1,27-2">Known for clear structure and balanced coverage of nursing content, and often recommended by nursing programs that already use HESI exams.</cite> Best for **programs integrating HESI exit exams** into their curriculum.

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6. Suggested Subject-Level Specialty Add-Ons (Optional Upsell/Modules)

For deeper subject-specific study (useful as add-on modules or bundled courses on medihelp.live):

Subject	Recommended Specialty Resource
Pharmacology	Kaplan NCLEX Medication Review (pocket-sized, 300+ meds)
Medical-Surgical	Lippincott Q&A Review for NCLEX (6,000+ questions by content area)
Dosage Calculations	*Dosage Calculations for Nursing Students* (formula-free method)
Clinical Judgment/NGN	*Next Generation NCLEX Prep* (case-based, NGN-specific)

Notes for Implementation on medihelp.live

- Structure each subject module as: **Concept Overview → Key Nursing Actions → NGN-style Practice Questions → Rationale Review**, matching how the real exam is built.
- Since NCSBN updates the test plan every 3 years, tag this content "Updated for the 2026–2029 Test Plan" and set a review reminder for ~2029.
- Consider a toggle/filter so a single question bank can be viewed as "RN view" or "PN view" given the significant content overlap.